

*The stolen hour is yours and the enemy's nest is behind you — and now word reaches you of one of your own. A brother of the Order, dead at the walls in the first night's blockade, and something he carried that no one thought to claim until it was too late.*

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*He was nobody much: a lay brother who kept the house's books and its psalter, the kind of man the great commanders never learn the name of — sent out with a thing to keep when keeping it grew dangerous, and left to keep it alone. The towns rose, the gates closed, and he went down in the dark with the Order's secret still on him and no one at his back. They left him where he fell. The Order forgets nothing, they say. It forgot him by morning.*

*And the doubt you have carried since the gates shut stirs again, looking at what is left of him. This is a master that taxes its own merchants to the bone, milks the towns it swears to shelter, begged the Emperor in Vienna for nothing and changed less — and still it spends men like this one in the dark, for secrets, and learns not a single name. The brothers were a thousand once; they are barely three hundred now. You push the thought down. It does not go far. Whose errand is this, in truth — and were they ever the ones in the right?*

*What the watch turned up on his body, they could make nothing of: a small instrument of iron tongues, the sort kept for the long offices and the colder hours; and folded against it, a scrap in a careful, cloister-trained hand — the same hand that had copied the house's psalter a hundred times over. Not a prayer, this time. A tune, set down note by note, and beneath it a line meant for one of his own:*

What the Order keeps, the Order does not leave in the open. I have set it where no townsman's hand would think to reach — behind our own music, the way we have always kept what is ours. Play the tune true, brother, note for note as it is sung in our house, and the number that unseals it is yours. Only our own know this melody. Only our own will pass.

*And here is the strange of it. As you read his hand, the tune is somehow already in the air — a thin, cold thread of it drifting down from the chapel stones, with no brother anywhere singing. As if the house had kept his music for him, and gives it back now that he cannot. It does not sound like the town's tunes. It never did. That is the point of it.*

*No one marks it. The whole city is piping and drumming itself hoarse tonight, drowning the bells; one more thread of music in the dark is nothing at all. So you listen. You take up his instrument and follow the tune note for note, writing down each number as it sounds.*

*Six numbers. The number a forgotten brother died keeping.*

↪ GAME MASTER — Bring the six numbers to the Game Master, who keeps to the Rynek Staromiejski (the Old Town market square). What the brother sealed away will be given to you in return — and with it, your next orders.